Capitals That Moved

Every capital move since 1500 in Wikidata, checked and corrected, with distances, directions and purpose-built capitals

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Abstract

States move their capitals more often than their apparent permanence suggests. I build a table of every move of a state's capital since 1500 that can be read from Wikidata's capital (P36) statements and their start and end qualifiers, and then check, correct and extend it by hand against cited sources. Of 2,978 capital statements for 2,295 states, only 21.3% carry a start or an end year, and 81% of present-day sovereign states have a single recorded capital. A transparent set of rules turns dated statements into 202 candidate moves since 1500; after removing 45 wrong or duplicated ones, correcting 5, confirming 22 and adding 42 that Wikidata lacks (Istanbul to Ankara, Kyoto to Tokyo, the wanderings of the Continental Congress and the Province of Canada, among others), the table holds 184 moves by 114 states, 136 lasting and 48 temporary. Every edit is documented with its source. The 20th century has the most moves (59). The median lasting move is 177 km; the longest is the Portuguese court's flight from Lisbon to Rio de Janeiro in 1808 (7,716 km), and the longest lasting move Muscat to Zanzibar in 1840 (3,924 km). 17 moves went to a capital built for the purpose, 12 of them after 1900. Since 1900, 27% of lasting moves left a coastal capital for the interior, against 8% before. The status of Indonesia's planned move to Nusantara is reported as of 2026: not made. The results describe the open record as much as history, and I report its gaps throughout.

Keywords: capital cities; capital relocation; planned capitals; historical geography; Wikidata; data quality; open data

1 Introduction

Capital cities look permanent, but many are not old in their role. Brasília was inaugurated in 1960, Abuja replaced Lagos in 1991, Naypyidaw was built in secret and occupied from 2005, and in 2026 Equatorial Guinea moved its capital from Malabo, on the island of Bioko, to Ciudad de la Paz on the mainland. Earlier, Peter the Great built St Petersburg and moved his court there from Moscow, and the Portuguese court ruled an empire from Rio de Janeiro for thirteen years. Capital relocation has a literature of its own, mostly on planned capitals and the motives behind them (Rossman, 2017; Schatz, 2004; Gordon, 2006), but there is no open, reusable table of every move with its date, distance and direction.

Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) comes close. It records the capitals of thousands of states, historical and present, often with the years each held the role. This paper asks how far a complete table of capital moves since 1500 can be read from it, what has to be corrected by hand, and what the resulting table shows: when moves happened, how far they went, which way, and how many went to capitals built for the purpose. An interactive map with a time slider accompanies it (https://maps.tristanhotham.com/moving-capitals/), and the data, with every manual edit and its source, are released for reuse.

Table 1: Hand edits to the automatic table, all listed with reasons and sources in `data/manual_edits.csv`.

Edit	Rows	Examples
Removed	45	Wrong order (Herat to Samarkand, 1507); institution not capital (Regensburg, Wetzlar); duplicate with a wrong year (Kraków to Warsaw, 1795); wrong item (West Pakistan); Republic of China and Vichy France statements replaced
Corrected	5	Moscow to St Petersburg 1730 to 1732; Muscat to Zanzibar 1824 to 1840; Diriyah to Riyadh 1819 to 1824; Helvetic Republic and Central America sequences
Confirmed	22	Rio to Brasília, Lagos to Abuja, Almaty to Astana, Yangon to Naypyidaw, Melbourne to Canberra and others
Added	42	Istanbul to Ankara; Kyoto to Tokyo; Karachi to Rawalpindi; Continental Congress 1776 to 1785; Province of Canada 1844 to 1866; Republic of China 1912 to 1949; France 1879 and 1940 to 1944
Merged	1	The same move on two items with different years, kept once
Same place	14	Pairs of names for one city (Edo and Tokyo, Constantinople and Istanbul), not counted
Relabelled	29	Display names only (Fengtian Fu as Mukden, Nan-ching as Nanjing)

2 Data

2.1 Wikidata

A query on the QLever Wikidata endpoint (QLever, 2026) returned every capital (P36) statement of items that are instances of country, sovereign state, historical country, kingdom, realm, republic, empire, ancient civilisation or constitutional monarchy, with the statement's start time (P580), end time (P582) and rank, the capital's coordinates (P625), the state's inception (P571) and dissolution (P576), and English labels. Collapsed to one record per statement, this gives 2,978 statements for 2,295 states, of which 1,652 existed after 1500. Only 634 statements (21.3%) have a start or an end year. 4 name an "unknown value" capital and 15 are deprecated (including Nusantara for Indonesia and St Petersburg for Russia). Present-day items usually hold only the current capital: of 197 present-day sovereign states, 159 (81%) have one. Past capitals are more often recorded on items for earlier regimes (the Tsardom of Russia, the Kingdom of Portugal, the British Raj).

2.2 Other sources

Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026) provides present-day country borders, land polygons (for distance from the sea) and populated places. The hand checks cite English Wikipedia articles for historical moves and, for 2026, news reports on Equatorial Guinea (africanews, 2026) and on Indonesia's Constitutional Court ruling on Nusantara (The Star, 2026; The Jakarta Post, 2026). All are listed in the edits file.

3 Methods

3.1 Reading moves from statements

For each state that existed after 1500, every statement that is not deprecated and names a located capital becomes a spell with a start year and an end year, either of which may be missing. Moves are read in two ways. First, where a spell B starts in year t, the old capital A is the other city whose spell ends within two years of t ("both ends dated"); failing that, a city whose spell began before t and has no end ("old capital's end not recorded"); failing that, the city whose spell ended most recently within 30 years before t ("gap"). A city whose spell runs on more than two years past t is treated as a joint capital, not one that was left. Second, where a spell A ends in year t and no move was found at t, the new capital is a city with no start date that runs on past t, the preferred-rank one if there are several. States whose several capitals have no dates at all (87) cannot be placed in time and are left out.

Moves of under 2 km, and a hand list of pairs that are the same city under two names or two Wikidata items (Edo and Tokyo, Constantinople and Istanbul, Buda and Budapest, Delhi and New Delhi), are set aside as renamings. The same move recorded on several items (both ends within 10 km, years within three) is counted once and the other items are listed with it. This gives 202 candidate moves since 1500 before the hand edits.

3.2 Checking and correcting by hand

I checked the moves people know best (Table 4) and every automatic move whose reading looked doubtful against cited sources, mostly English Wikipedia articles, and recorded each decision in `data/manual_edits.csv` with a reason and a link (Table 1). Removals fall into four kinds: an undated capital read as the successor when it was the predecessor (Samarkand for the Timurids, Gulbarga for the Bahmanis, Malbork for the Teutonic Order); the seat of an institution read as the capital (the Imperial Diet at Regensburg, the Imperial Chamber Court at Wetzlar); the same move on another item with a different year (Kraków to Warsaw in 1795 rather than 1596; Lisbon to Rio de Janeiro in 1815 rather than 1808); and statements on the wrong item (Pakistan's capitals recorded on the West Pakistan province). Where Wikidata mixes parallel governments (Vichy France and Free France; the Republic of China's overlapping statements for Beijing under several names), I replaced its moves with a checked sequence. Additions cover famous moves Wikidata does not record: Istanbul to Ankara (1923), Karachi to Rawalpindi (1959), Kyoto to Tokyo (1868), the Continental Congress's moves from 1776 to 1785, the Province of Canada's alternating seats from 1844 to 1866, the colonial capitals of Côte d'Ivoire, Belize City to Belmopan (1970), Manila to Quezon City and back (1948, 1976) and Colombo to Kotte (1982). Where I was not sure of a fact, I left Wikidata as it is and let the confidence flag speak.

3.3 Measures

Distance is the great-circle (haversine) distance between the two capitals' coordinates on a sphere of radius 6,371 km; direction is the initial bearing, binned into eight compass points. Each move is assigned to the present-day country where most of its state's capitals lie (Natural Earth). Distance from the sea is to the nearest point of the Natural Earth 1:50m land outline, so inland seas and lakes such as the Caspian and Lake Tanganyika do not count. For moves within one present-day country I also compute the change in distance to the centroid of the country's largest polygon. A move is temporary if the new seat was held for less than a year, if the capital was back in the

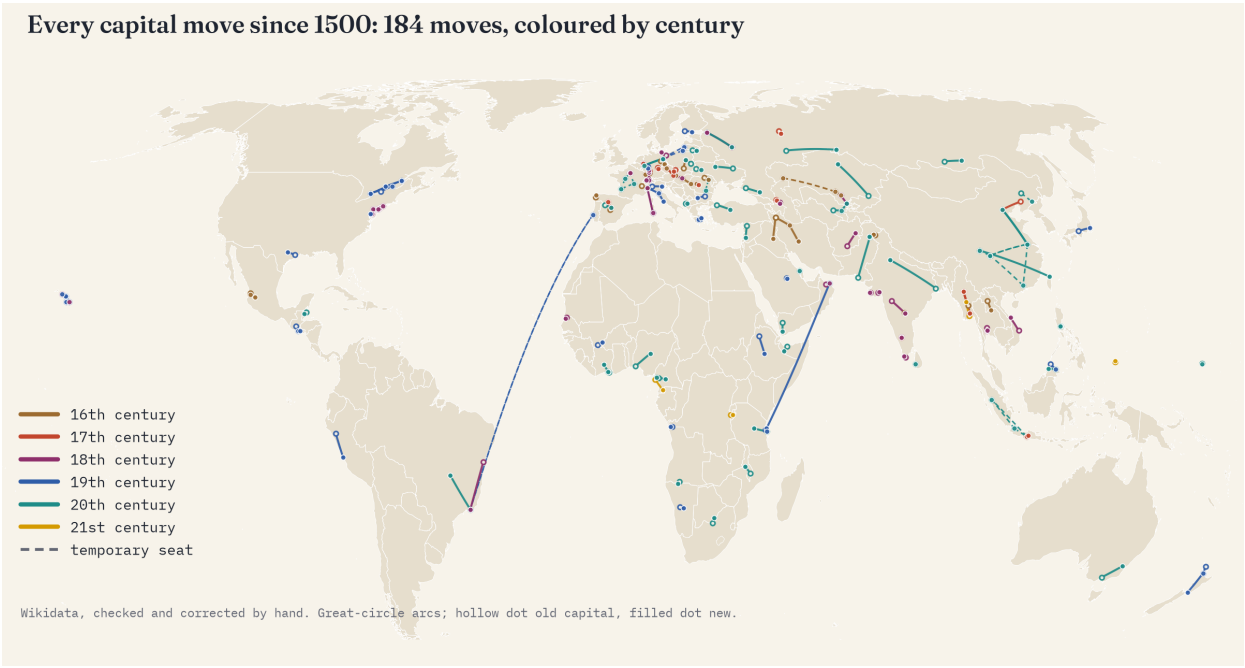


Figure 1: Every capital move since 1500 in the table, as great-circle arcs from the old capital (hollow) to the new (filled), coloured by century; dashed arcs are temporary seats.

starting city within ten years, or if it is a wartime or exile seat in a short hand list (the Portuguese court in Rio, the Sardinian court in Cagliari, Indonesia's revolutionary capitals, Prussia's refuge in Memel). Purpose-built capitals are a hand list of cities founded, or laid out as new towns, to be capitals (Wikipedia, 2026). Each move carries a confidence flag: checked (confirmed or added by hand from a cited source), high (both ends dated consistently in Wikidata), medium (one end dated) or low (a gap).

4 Results

4.1 How many, and when

The table holds 184 moves since 1500 by 114 states in 66 present-day countries: 136 lasting and 48 temporary (Figure 1). 142 come from Wikidata (of them 111 with both ends dated) and 42 were added by hand; 69 in all are checked against a source.

The 20th century has the most moves, 59 (44 lasting), against 42 in the 19th and 37 in the 18th (Table 2, Figure 2). The busiest decade is the 1940s (18 moves, 7 lasting) and the busiest year 1949 (5), when the Republic of China moved from Nanjing to Guangzhou, Chongqing, Chengdu and finally Taipei. The 21st century, 26 years old, already has 4: Naypyidaw (2005), Ngerulmud (2006), Gitega (2019) and Ciudad de la Paz (2026). The low counts before 1700 partly reflect the record: Wikidata is rich for small European principalities of that period and thin for Africa, Asia and the Americas before colonial rule.

4.2 How far

Most moves are short. The median lasting move is 177 km (mean 288 km); 36% of lasting moves are under 100 km and 21 are over 500 km. The shortest are moves across a river or to a new palace

Table 2: Moves by century.

Century	Moves	Lasting	Temporary	Added by hand	Median km
16th century	26	22	4	1	156
17th century	16	14	2	1	75
18th century	37	24	13	9	133
19th century	42	28	14	11	205
20th century	59	44	15	20	309
21st century	4	4	0	0	196
All	184	136	48	42	201

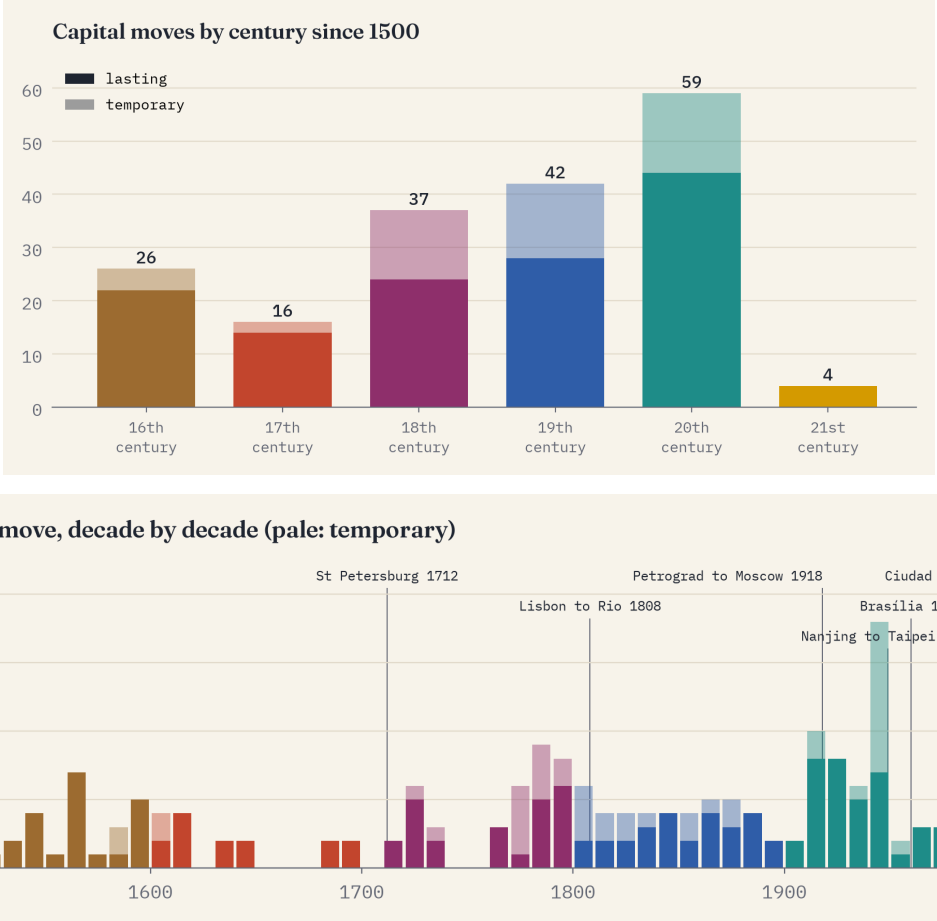


Figure 2: Moves by century (top) and by decade (bottom), with temporary moves pale.

town: Thonburi to Bangkok in 1782 (4 km), Muharraq to Manama in 1921, Durlach to Karlsruhe in 1715. The longest is the Portuguese court's flight from Napoleon, Lisbon to Rio de Janeiro in 1808 (7,716 km), twice the next (Table 3, Figure 3). The longest lasting move is Said bin Sultan's transfer of the Omani capital from Muscat to Stone Town, Zanzibar, in 1840 (3,924 km), followed by Chengdu to Taipei (1,828 km) and Calcutta to Delhi (1,305 km). 14 moves exceed 1,000 km.

4.3 Capitals built for the purpose

17 moves went to a city founded, or laid out as a new town, to be a capital (Figure 4). Early examples are palace and residence towns (Versailles, Karlsruhe) and St Petersburg; Washington was planned from 1791. 12 of the 17 came after 1900: New Delhi, Canberra, Quezon City, Brasília, Gaborone, Islamabad, Belmopan, Palikir, Abuja, Naypyidaw, Ngerulmud and Ciudad de la Paz.

Table 3: The ten longest moves since 1500 (great-circle distance).

Move	Year	State	km	Kind
Lisbon to Rio de Janeiro	1808	Kingdom of Portugal	7,716	temporary
Muscat to Zanzibar	1840	Omani Empire	3,924	lasting
Chengdu to Taipei	1949	Republic of China	1,828	lasting
Yogyakarta to Bukittinggi	1948	Indonesia	1,388	temporary
Calcutta to Delhi	1911	British Raj	1,305	lasting
Sighnaq to Saray-Jük	1511	Kazakh Khanate	1,235	temporary
Saray-Jük to Sighnaq	1521	Kazakh Khanate	1,235	temporary
Salvador to Rio de Janeiro	1763	State of Brazil	1,211	lasting
Nanjing to Chongqing	1937	Republic of China	1,200	temporary
Chongqing to Nanjing	1946	Republic of China	1,200	temporary

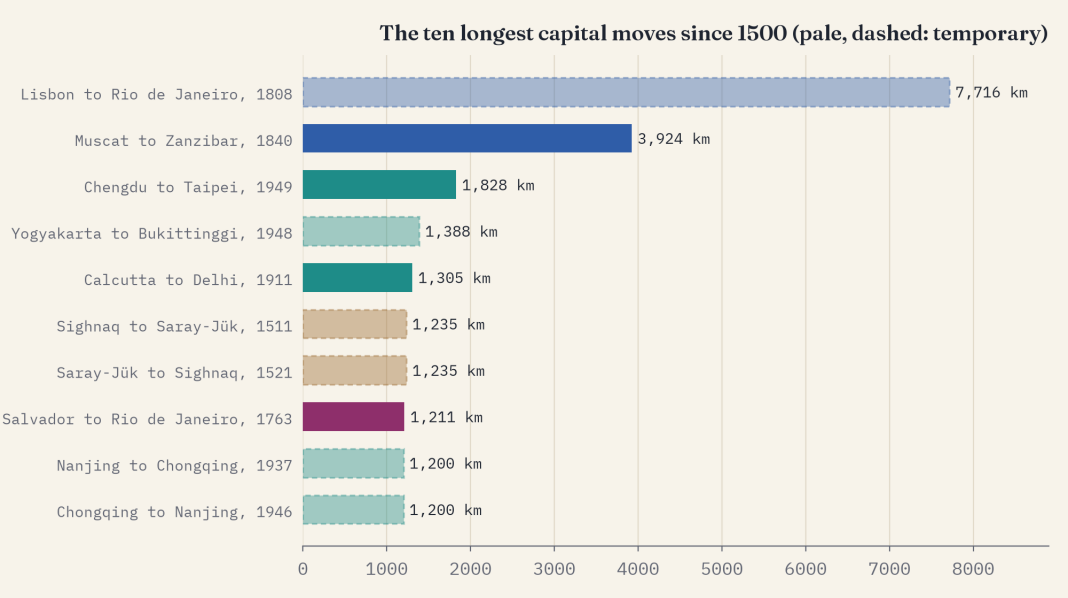


Figure 3: The ten longest moves; pale, dashed bars are temporary seats.

They are 25% of all lasting moves since 1900. Several famous relocations went to existing towns rather than new ones (Ankara, Dodoma, Yamoussoukro, Lilongwe, Astana, formerly Akmola) and are not counted as purpose-built.

4.4 Inland and towards the centre

Of 48 lasting moves since 1900, 13 (27%) left a capital within 50 km of the sea for one at least 50 km further inland, against 7 of 88 (8%) before 1900 (Figure 5). The pattern is the post-colonial and nation-building move from a port to the interior: Rio to Brasília, Lagos to Abuja, Dar es Salaam to Dodoma, Abidjan to Yamoussoukro, Yangon to Naypyidaw, Karachi to Rawalpindi and Islamabad, Malabo to Ciudad de la Paz; Melbourne to Canberra and Istanbul to Ankara fit it too. Only 1 went the other way, the Republic of China's retreat to Taipei. Of 45 lasting moves since 1900 within one present-day country, 25 brought the capital at least 25 km closer to the centroid of the country's main landmass and 11 took it further away; Brasília is 916 km closer to Brazil's centre than Rio, Abuja 535 km closer to Nigeria's than Lagos. Directions are otherwise mixed: 24 lasting moves went east and 11 north.

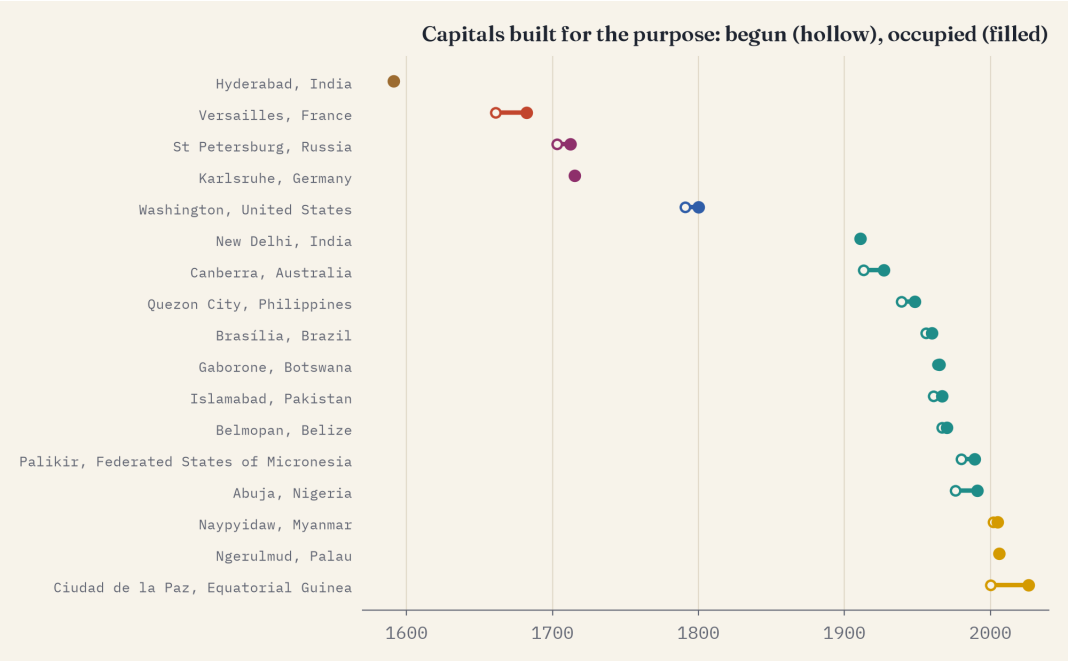


Figure 4: Purpose-built capitals: when building began or the city was founded (hollow) and when the government moved in (filled).

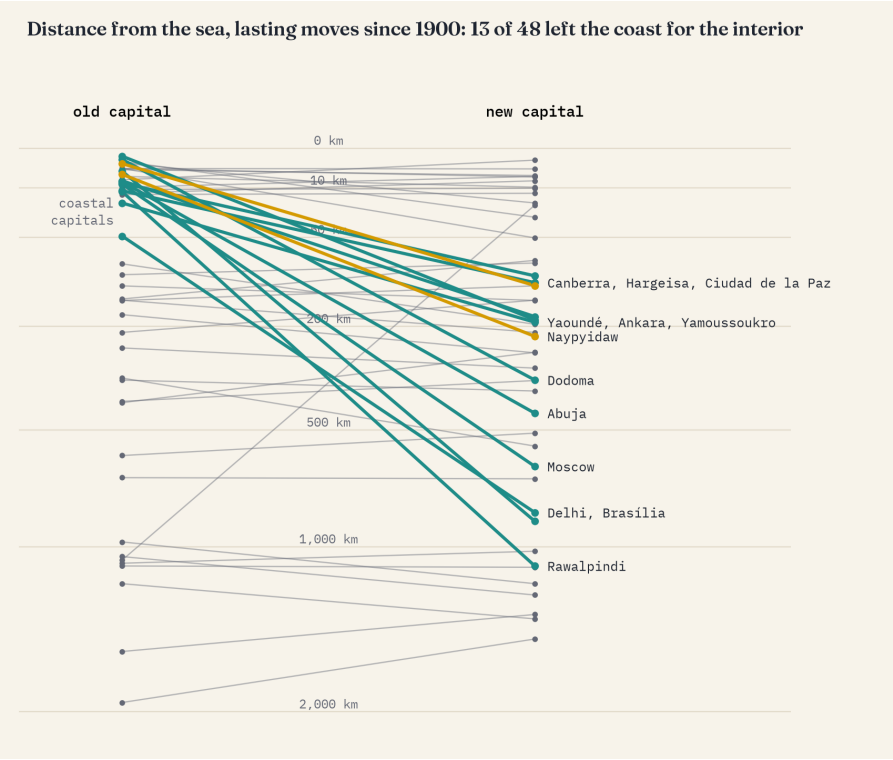


Figure 5: Distance from the sea of the old and new capital, lasting moves since 1900 (square-root scale). Coloured: from the coast to the interior.

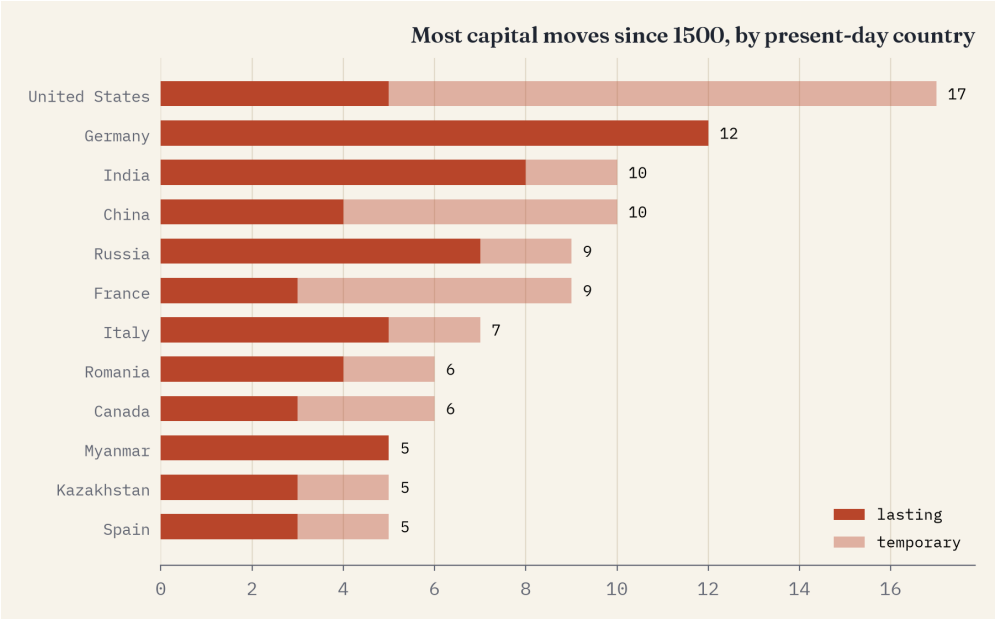


Figure 6: Most moves since 1500 by present-day country; pale: temporary.

4.5 Who moved most

By present-day country the United States has the most moves (17, 5 lasting), 11 of them the Continental Congress and early federal government between 1776 and 1800, the rest the Kingdom of Hawai'i and the Republic of Texas (Figure 6). Germany follows with 12, from 8 separate states, then India and China (10 each) and Russia and France (9 each). Counted by state, the most mobile are the United States (11), the Republic of China (8), France (7) and the Province of Canada (6), whose parliament alternated between Toronto and Quebec City before settling in Ottawa. 35 present-day countries have two or more moves. These counts measure the record as much as restlessness: they are highest where Wikidata or my additions are most detailed.

4.6 The famous moves

Of the 24 famous moves in Table 4, 18 were in Wikidata, several recorded twice or with a second, wrong year; the rest had to be added. Tanzania's and Côte d'Ivoire's moves are dated by the decision or the move of the legislature, not of the whole government: Dodoma was chosen in 1973, the National Assembly moved in 1996 and most ministries around 2019, and most of the government stayed in Abidjan after 1983. Germany's capital became Berlin on reunification in 1990, but the government moved from Bonn only in 1999.

4.7 Moves planned, and one made in 2026

Indonesia's planned move to Nusantara, in East Kalimantan (1,240 km from Jakarta), has not been made. A 2022 law names Nusantara as the new capital, but the transfer takes effect only with a presidential decree, which had not been issued; in May 2026 the Constitutional Court confirmed that Jakarta remains the capital until it is (The Star, 2026; The Jakarta Post, 2026), and the government's stated aim is to make Nusantara a "political capital" by 2028. Wikidata marks Nusantara's capital statement as deprecated. Equatorial Guinea's move to Ciudad de la Paz, by a decree reported in January 2026 that gave government bodies a year to relocate (africanews, 2026), is included as the newest move.

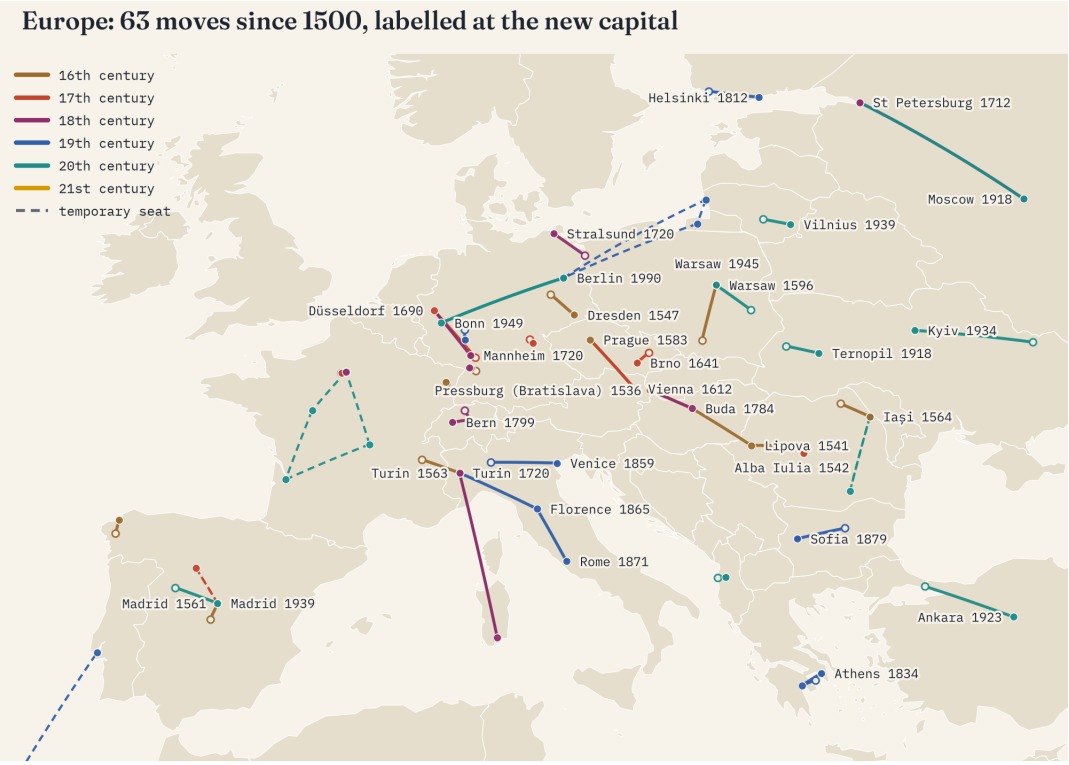


Figure 7: Europe, where the record is densest, labelled at the new capital.

5 Limitations

The table is a reading of an open, collaboratively edited database, corrected where I checked it, not a complete history. It misses moves that Wikidata does not record and I did not add, and its coverage is far richer for Europe, and for colonial administrations, than for pre-colonial Africa, Asia and the Americas. "Capital" means the state's recorded capital, which for early modern monarchies is often the court or a ruler's residence; several countries divide the functions of a capital (Bolivia, the Netherlands, South Africa, Benin, Malaysia), and some moves transferred the title or parliament long before the ministries. Dates in Wikidata for medieval and early modern states are often rounded to the year and sometimes disputed, so "high" confidence means internal consistency, not historical certainty. Most hand checks rest on English Wikipedia articles, which are themselves secondary. The classification of temporary moves and of purpose-built capitals involves judgement, set out in the code. Distances are between the coordinates Wikidata gives for each city, so short moves within a growing city (Rawalpindi to Islamabad, 11 km) depend on where those points lie.

6 Conclusion

Capital moves are common: 184 since 1500 in this table, with the 20th century the busiest and the planned interior capital its signature. The open record can produce such a table, but not on its own. Its dates are sparse, its items overlap, and several of the best-known moves are missing or misplaced, so a reusable table needs explicit rules, hand checking and a full log of the edits. That log is part of the contribution: it shows where Wikidata could be improved, and the data, code and edits are released so that others can extend them.

Table 4: The famous moves checked by hand: whether Wikidata had them, and the source used.

Move	Year	State	km	Status	Source
Rio de Janeiro to Brasília	1960	Brazil	931	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Brasília
Calcutta to Delhi	1911	British Raj	1,305	in Wikidata, checked	WP: New Delhi
St Petersburg to Moscow	1728	Russian Empire	635	in Wikidata, checked	
St Petersburg to Moscow	1918	Russian Socialist Federative Soviet Republic	635	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Moscow
Istanbul to Ankara	1923	Republic of Turkey	349	added by hand	WP: Ankara
Lagos to Abuja	1991	Nigeria	536	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Abuja
Karachi to Rawalpindi	1959	Pakistan	1,135	added by hand	WP: Islamabad
Rawalpindi to Islamabad	1967	Pakistan	11	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Islamabad
Almaty to Astana	1997	Kazakhstan	970	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Astana
Yangon to Naypyidaw	2005	Myanmar	328	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Naypyidaw
Dar es Salaam to Dodoma	1996	Tanzania	397	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Dodoma
Abidjan to Yamoussoukro	1983	Ivory Coast	215	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Yamoussoukro
Berlin to Bonn	1949	Germany	476	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Bonn
Bonn to Berlin	1990	Germany	476	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Berlin/Bonn Act
Melbourne to Canberra	1927	Australia	466	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Canberra
Kyoto to Tokyo	1868	Japan	364	added by hand	WP: Tokyo
Lisbon to Rio de Janeiro	1808	Kingdom of Portugal	7,716	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Transfer of the Portuguese cou
Rio de Janeiro to Lisbon	1821	Portuguese Empire	7,716	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Transfer of the Portuguese cou
New York to Philadelphia	1790	United States	130	in Wikidata, checked	WP: List of capitals in the United
Philadelphia to Washington	1800	United States	199	in Wikidata, checked	WP: List of capitals in the United
Quebec City to Ottawa	1866	Province of Canada	379	added by hand	WP: Canadian seat of government di
Beijing to Nanjing	1928	Republic of China	898	added by hand	WP: Capital of the Republic of Chi
Nanjing to Beijing	1912	Republic of China	898	added by hand	WP: Capital of the Republic of Chi
Mukden (Shenyang) to Beijing	1644	Qing dynasty	627	in Wikidata, checked	WP: Shenyang

Data and code availability

Data (moves, manual edits with sources, renamings set aside, planned moves, results) and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/moving-capitals and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.
Interactive version: https://maps.tristanhotham.com/moving-capitals/. Wikidata is CC0; Natural Earth is public domain. This paper, the figures and the derived data are released under CC BY 4.0; code under MIT.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

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